

ROOTED: Design, Culture, and Community

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Free

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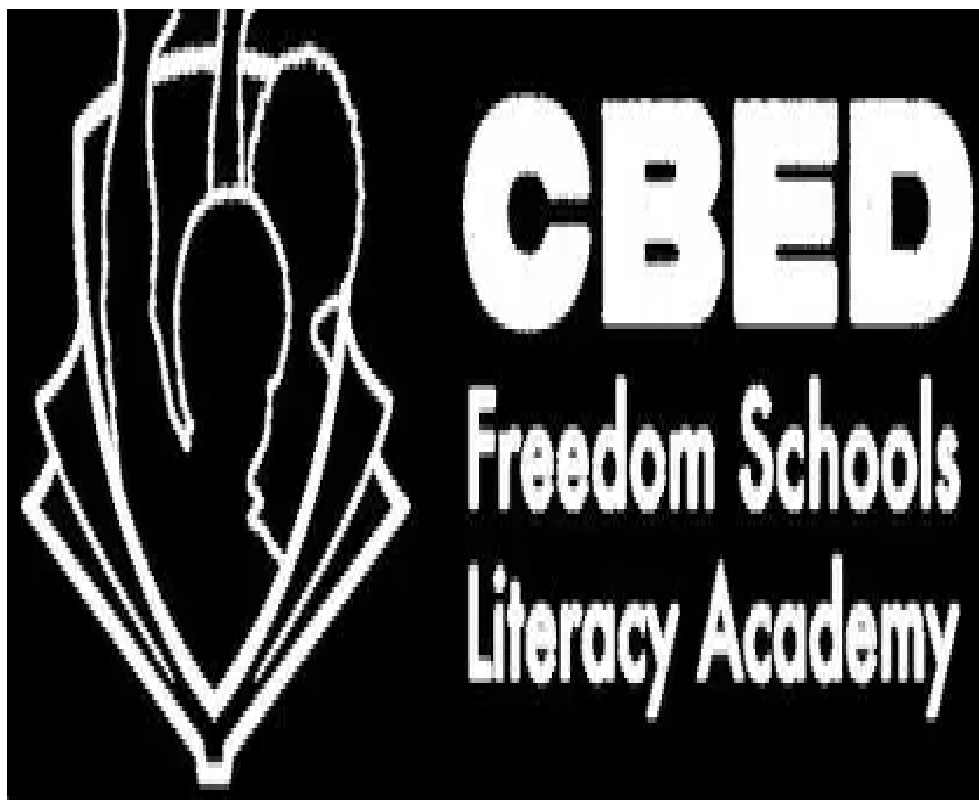
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Placeholder images sourced for
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All writing and design concepts
by Isaac Sanders.

FROM THE EDITOR

Design is never neutral. Every space, every layout, every visual choice communicates something about who belongs, who is centered, and who is invited to thrive. As an early childhood educator and designer, I've learned that the environments we create are powerful—they can affirm identity, spark curiosity, and build community, or they can silence and exclude.

This issue of ROOTED brings together my design work, my Freedom Schools experience, and my commitment to culturally grounded, human-centered spaces. I wanted to create a publication that honors

Isaac R. Sanders

EDITOR-IN-



this.

BEENA CHOPRA, MUMBAI

IMPACT OF EDUCATION

Kicker:

A classroom is more than a room—it's a cultural ecosystem. When designed with



BY Isaac R. Sanders
PHOTOGRAPHY BY JAYA SOOD





Representation is not a trend—it is a responsibility. When children see books, posters, and materials that reflect their racial, cultural, and linguistic identities, they receive a powerful message: your story belongs here. Representation also expands the worldview of all students, helping them understand that diversity is a strength, not an exception.

Designers and educators must move beyond tokenism. Representation should be woven into the everyday fabric of the classroom, not reserved for heritage months or special occasions. When representation is consistent, it becomes a natural part of the learning environment.

Why Space Shapes Identity

Children learn who they are by how adults respond to them—and by how spaces respond to them. A classroom that welcomes movement, collaboration, and emotional expression tells students that their full selves are accepted. A classroom that restricts, silences, or polices

THE VALUE OF JOY

Cheers and chants are central to the Freedom Schools model, grounding each day in rhythm, affirmation, and collective energy. They are more than fun—they are a culturally rooted pedagogy that builds identity, confidence, and community

Joy is a radical act in systems that often suppress it. For Black and Brown children, cheers and chants counteract deficit narratives by affirming brilliance and possibility. They remind students that their voices matter and that learning can feel like home. Joy becomes a form of resistance, a way of reclaiming space in environments that have historically marginalized them.

When you've decided on your cover story, come up with a list of topics for your feature articles. This can range from interviews, product reviews, human interest pieces and even lists. Think about what your audience would be interested in and get writing! Again, choose engaging photos and graphics to accompany your words, as these also help catch your audience's eye.

BY ARYAN LODHI
PHOTOGRAPHY BY ISHAAN MINHAS



“Joy is not extra, its essential”

Inclusive design begins with the belief that all children deserve access to learning without unnecessary barriers. This means designing materials, spaces, and routines that support a wide range of abilities, languages, and learning styles. When teachers plan with flexibility in mind, they create environments where every child can participate meaningfully. Universal Design for Learning (UDL) encourages educators to offer multiple ways for students to engage, express themselves, and understand content. This approach doesn't lower expectations—it expands pathways to success.

Removing Barriers Before They Appear

Too often, accessibility is treated as an afterthought. Inclusive design flips this mindset by anticipating needs before they arise. This might look like offering visual supports, providing flexible seating, or using clear, consistent layouts that reduce cognitive load. When barriers are removed proactively, students experience learning as something designed for them, not something they must struggle



Image Caption:
Students raising their voices together during morning Harambee.



CHEERS AND CHANTS: JOY AS PEDAGOGY



In Freedom Schools, joy is not an afterthought—it is a teaching strategy rooted in Black cultural tradition.

BY Isaac R. Sanders
PHOTOGRAPHY BY ISHAAN MINHAS



“Images help children make meaning before language catches up.”

Children read images long before they read words.

Why Images Matter

Images are children’s first texts. Before they can decode letters, young learners interpret meaning through pictures, symbols, and visual cues. Strong visual storytelling helps children build vocabulary, make predictions, and connect ideas. It also supports multilingual learners by offering non-linguistic pathways to understanding

Storytelling as Cultural Memory

Visual storytelling is a powerful way to preserve and share cultural knowledge. When children see illustrations, photographs, and symbols that reflect their heritage, they develop a deeper sense of identity and pride. Visuals also help children understand perspectives beyond their own, fostering empathy and curiosity.

Designing for Young Eyes

Designing visuals for young learners requires clarity, contrast, and intentionality. Children benefit from images that are bold, uncluttered, and easy to interpret. Consistent iconography, color coding, and visual routines help students navigate the classroom independently and confidently

After writing all your articles and adding them to your layout, list down all the titles to set up your table of contents. You can add a brief description for each article or keep it simple and paste the feature titles on the page. Don't forget your page numbers too!

